

First Year Survival Guide

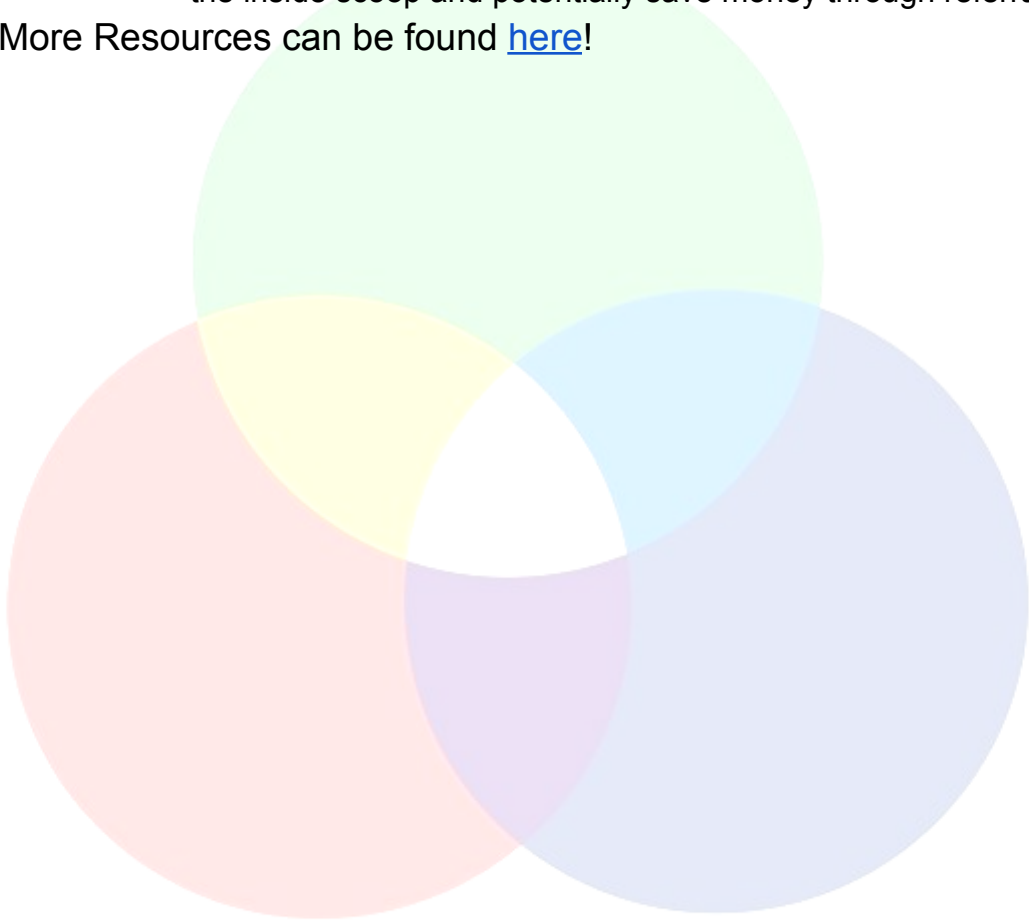
Last Updated: September 3, 2024

- Front Office Staff
 - Swing by the front office if you need office supplies.
 - Get to know the staff by checking this [out!](#)
- Physical Space
 - You can reserve a conference room if it's free on the [schedule](#). It could be for study or research.
 - Check to see if it is available ahead of time and email the [front office](#) to reserve it!
 - You can also reserve a room in the Engineering building as an employee: check this [link](#) out!
 - Be sure to note that you're a graduate assistant.
 - There are small, private pods in the first floor elevator lobby that are perfect for virtual meetings.
 - For regulations about the office space, [here](#) are the rules last updated in 2019 (still standing 2022).
 - The fridges are open use, but put your name and date on it if it will stay for multiple days.
 - The office space is clearly designed to be a collaborative environment. Feel free to write on whiteboards and use the pillars and/or study rooms!
 - If you do write on the boards, please erase once you are done! It's totally okay to leave work you're still working on, but please put "DNE" (Do not Erase) on each board panel you'd like to stay. It's advisable to take a picture of anything important as well in case someone erases it by mistake.
 - Have questions, comments, or concerns about the norms of CMSE? Fill out this [poll](#) or come talk to GSO leadership. We understand norms are fluid over time.
 - The College of Engineering has a small graduate student lounge in EB 2420. It has free snacks!
- Surviving the Winter!
 - It gets quite cold but it's totally fine when you have appropriate clothing!
 - When buying a winter coat, buy a size up and/or wear a hoodie when you try it on.

- Nice winter boots are very helpful for those cold mornings. To prevent burning up in the office, a lot of CMSE grad students keep a pair of desk shoes such as slippers or sandals.
 - Lansing is one of the cloudiest metros in the country. Buying a [Sunshine lamp](#) does wonders for your circadian rhythm and taking Vitamin D supplements helps mitigate seasonal depression. Put the lamp in your apartment or on your desk in the office.
- Printing
 - To print color, use one of the [DECS](#) printers. You have an annual quota, but be careful because printing posters goes through your quota.
 - To print in black and white, there is a printer on each floor of the CMSE Grad Space; look [here](#) for instructions.
- Involvement and Communication
 - Make sure to join the [CMSE Grad Slack](#)!
 - GSO sends out a newsletter called *1515 Times* that has great ways to get involved in the graduate student community.
 - As a first year student, you automatically get assigned a mentor from an older cohort; they are a great resource, and you get free stuff.
 - Meet the GSO Exec Board [here](#)!
 - First Year Liaison!
 - The current FYL is [Ian Freeman](#)! He'll be the main point of contact for you.
 - The FYL is elected at the beginning of every spring semester with two main goals:
 - Be the voice for and connect first year students with the greater graduate student community.
 - Get to know the department's administrative mechanics.
 - Reach out to Ian or another GSO Exec if this position might interest you!
- Advisor Mentorship
 - The Graduate School has developed "[Guidelines for Graduate Student Mentoring and Advising](#)."
 - Additionally, they have formed the Student-Advisor Expectation Scales document that can be found [here](#).
 - It is generally a good idea to talk with your advisor about these at least once during graduate school—the earlier the better.
 - More information could be found [here](#).
 - If there is any trouble or you are unsure of how to proceed, MSU's [Office of the University Ombudsperson](#) is a fantastic resource for advice, guidelines, and knowledge of the different paths you can take.

- Having meaningful conversations with your advisor about graduate student expectations, research goals, and career ambitions is critical for the success of the graduate student–advisor relationship. Talk to your advisor your Individual Development Plan (IDP) and schedule a meeting where you both can discuss in detail. An IDP is a living document and will be shaped as you continue on your graduate journey. It is recommended to revisit this document annually with your advisor to ensure you are both in agreement with the goals outlined in your IDP. An example from the Stanford Office of Postdoctoral Affairs is linked [here](#).
- **Classes**
 - Your first year, you take the Core Courses and they are difficult. As GSO, we can't make the workload easier, but we can decrease the stress.
 - We'll offer study breaks each semester centered around your midterms and finals. Taking time to decompress is important.
 - Whenever you're struggling, know that your classmates probably are too. They are your biggest ally in this! Make a study group, go over homework together, etc.
 - We understand that the professors who teach the classes can be intimidating, but they are nice, sweet, and supportive and want to see you succeed! Stop by office hours for any questions you might have.
 - Some older students have created some preliminary material for some of the core courses. Take a look to dust off your skills or develop new ones:
 - [CMSE 821](#)
 - [CMSE 823](#)
- **Parking**
 - Grad students are eligible for a parking pass for the semester. It gets you access to any employee lot *South* of the Red Cedar River
 - If you have any questions, ask someone on the GSO leadership team for the ins and outs.
- **Logistics**
 - The [Graduate Handbook](#) can be found here!
 - If it's a random question, here's a [slack workspace](#) with graduate students and faculty!
 - Graduate Director: [Dr. Rachel Frisbie](#)
 - Here is her [calendar booking](#) page.
 - Graduate Coordinator: [Karen DeCaire](#)
 - Department Chair: [Dr. Ed Brown](#)
 - Travel reimbursement and accounts related issues:
 - Talk to your supervisor/advisor first
 - Dept Accountant: [Carolyn Wemple](#)

- Housing
 - [Here](#) is a link to housing in the greater East Lansing area that's popular among CMSE grad students.
 - Ask folks if people are living where you're interested– you can get the inside scoop and potentially save money through referrals!
- More Resources can be found [here](#)!



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